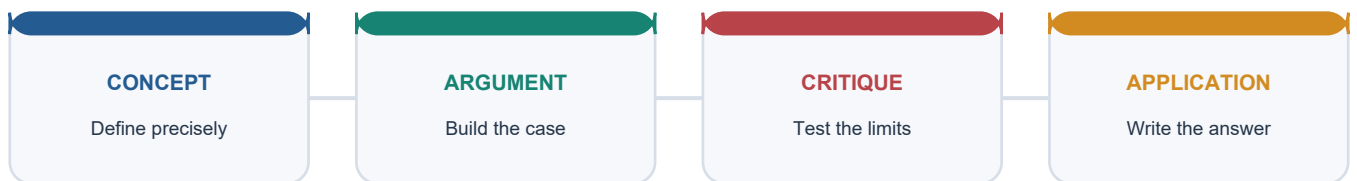


COMPLETE LEARNING SESSION

UPSC Qualifying English - Complete Skills Guide

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

UPSC Qualifying English - Complete Skills Guide

One continuous language-learning guide. It covers grammar, usage, vocabulary, comprehension, précis, essay writing, translation where applicable, readiness and examination method. It contains no artificial GS learning-session sequence.

PART 01 - README

Paper: Compulsory English | **Standard:** Matriculation or equivalent **Nature:** Qualifying; marks are not counted for ranking. **Official aim:** Read and understand serious discursive prose and express ideas clearly and correctly. **Status discipline:** Paper-format observations below are local-source evidence, not a substitute for the notification applicable to a future examination.

Source register - local official paper samples

Year	Local file	Header/status checked	Use in this kit
2018	books/more_previous_papers/ENGLISH-COMP_0.pdf	Extracted header: 3 hours, 300 marks	Format and demand sample
2019	books/more_previous_papers/QP-CSM19-EnglishCompulsory.pdf	Extracted header says 800 ; section arithmetic is $100+75+75+25+25=300$	Use section arithmetic only; header requires visual reconciliation
2020	books/more_previous_papers/ENGLISH(1).pdf	Extracted header: 3 hours, 300 marks	Format and demand sample
2021	books/more_previous_papers/English.pdf	Extracted header: 3 hours, 300 marks	Format and demand sample
2022	books/more_previous_papers/QP-CSM-22-ENGLISH-Comp1-280922.pdf	Extracted header: 3 hours, 300 marks	Format and demand sample
2023	books/more_previous_papers/QP-CSM-23-ENGLISH-COMPULSORY-290923.pdf	Extracted header: 3 hours, 300 marks	Format and demand sample
2025	books/more_previous_papers/ENGLISH-COMPULSORY-QP-CSM-25-010925.pdf	Extracted header: 3 hours, 300 marks	Format and demand sample

FACT: Across these samples, the usable section pattern is: essay about 600 words (100), comprehension ($5 \times 15 = 75$), précis about one-third (75), and usage/vocabulary ($25+25$). All sampled papers direct the candidate not to give a précis title; 2025 says “Do not give or suggest a title.” This kit additionally practises title questions as an unfamiliar-comprehension demand, not as a claimed past-paper précis instruction.

ANALYSIS: Current qualifying minimum: The official syllabus confirms qualifying/non-ranking status, but the current-notification minimum has not been line-verified here. Do not rely on an unsourced “ $25\% = 75/300$ ” claim. After verification against the applicable UPSC notification, record its URL, publication date and exact clause in 00_Readiness-Tracker.md.

ANALYSIS: Non-official coaching safety target: 120/300 overall, plus the section floors in 00_Master-Framework.md. It is deliberately distinct from any official eligibility rule.

Paper architecture

Official area	Core owner	Diagnostic owner
Comprehension of given passages	Core 06	Mocks 1 and 2
Precis writing	Core 06	Mocks 1 and 2
Usage and vocabulary	basic/01 to basic/05	Foundation Test; Mocks 1 and 2
Short essays	Core 07	Mocks 1 and 2

Practice order and decision gates

1. Complete `practice/01_Foundation-Test.md` and correct it with `answer-keys/01_Foundation-Test-Key.md`. This diagnoses usage only; it cannot certify reading/writing readiness.
2. Complete the worked exercises in Core 06 and Core 07 without looking at the keys.
3. Attempt Mock 1 in exactly three hours; use its key only afterwards.
4. Repair every missed demand family in the Core owners and record the result in the tracker.
5. Attempt the independent Mock 2 in exactly three hours. Use its key only afterwards.
6. A candidate is **not mock-ready** until both timed mocks meet the non-official safety target, no section is below its floor, and every error is classified and repaired.

PART 02 - 00 Master-Framework

WORD CHOICE + GRAMMAR + PUNCTUATION + SENTENCE LOGIC
|
v
COMPREHENSION -> PRÉCIS -> ESSAY -> TIMED, REVISED SCRIPT

Non-negotiable scoring principle

The paper tests **correct, clear and concise English**, not ornamental writing. Prefer a short correct sentence to a long sentence whose agreement, punctuation or logic is uncertain. Answer the precise command; do not substitute outside knowledge for the passage.

Status, source and safety rule

FACT: The official syllabus owner, `./OFFICIAL-UPSC-CSE-SYLLABUS-VERBATIM.md`, states that English is of Matriculation/equivalent standard, is qualifying, and does not count for ranking.

FACT: The local 2018, 2020-2023 and 2025 paper headers show a three-hour, 300-mark paper. The 2019 scan's extracted header reads "800"; this is an OCR-status defect, **not** a fact to reproduce: its printed section arithmetic is $100 + 75 + 75 + 25 + 25 = 300$. See `README.md` for the source register.

ANALYSIS: **Current-notification threshold status (15 August 2026)**: this kit has not line-verified the 2026 UPSC notification clause on the qualifying minimum. The official PDF URL could not be retrieved in this session (403/404). Do **not** treat "25% = 75/300" as a verified current-notification rule until the candidate checks the notification applicable to their examination.

ANALYSIS: **Non-official safety target**: until that verification is recorded, use **120/300 or more** on each independently timed mock, with at least 35/100 in essay, 30/75 in comprehension, 30/75 in précis and 20/50 in usage. These are coaching safeguards, not UPSC cut-offs.

Exact 180-minute attempt plan

Task	Time	Checkpoint
Scan instructions; choose and outline essay	8 min	Chosen topic, qualified thesis, four-point outline
Essay	42 min	About 600 words; reserve final 4 minutes to count and revise
Comprehension	34 min	Underline command words; answer every subpart
Précis	43 min	Map ideas, calculate target, draft, count and polish
Usage and vocabulary	38 min	Complete certain items first; leave no avoidable blank
Final script revision and contingency	15 min	5-minute reserve for overflow; 10-minute error sweep
Total	180 min	

If a section overruns, use the 5-minute reserve first, then stop at the hard section boundary. Do not sacrifice final checking to perfect one answer.

Error-control checklist

Before submitting, check:

1. Every sentence has a finite verb.
2. Subject and verb agree.
3. Pronouns have clear antecedents.
4. Tense does not shift without reason.
5. Articles and prepositions are idiomatic.
6. Commas do not join two complete sentences by themselves.
7. Apostrophes show possession or omission, never an ordinary plural.
8. Essay paragraphs have one controlling idea and advance the thesis.
9. Comprehension answers use the passage, answer every part and distinguish fact from inference.
10. Précis preserves the thesis, major idea units and concessions at about the instructed proportion, in independent connected prose.
11. Count essay and précis words; obey title/no-title instructions literally.
12. Strike out accidental repetition, unsupported statistics, quotations and decorative flourishes.

PART 03 - 00 Readiness-Tracker

Use after every timed attempt. The target bands here are **non-official coaching safeguards**, not UPSC cut-offs.

Notification-verification record

Examination/​year	Official notification URL or local copy	Publication date	Exact qualifying clause	Verified by/ ​date	Status
CSE 2026	Not recorded	-	-	-	ANALYSIS: Unverified; do not assume 25%=75/​300

Diagnostic dashboard

Attempt	Timed requirement	Essay /​100	Comprehension /​75	Précis /​75	Usage	Total /​300	Safety target met?
Foundation Test	90 min	-	-	-	/​8203;85	-	Usage diagnostic only
Mock 1							
Mock 2							

Non-official safety gate: 120/300 overall; essay ≥35, comprehension ≥30, précis ≥30, usage ≥20. Meet it in **both** independent mocks.

Section diagnostic rules

Symptom	Diagnosis	Repair owner before next mock
Misses command, tone, title, reference or context meaning	Reading-​demand failure	basic/​06 §§1-3
Omits one limb of a question	Multipart allocation failure	basic/​06 §2
Correct ideas but wrong ratio/​title/​copied wording	Précis execution failure	basic/​06 §§4-7
Essay describes but has no arguable position	Thesis/​structure failure	basic/​07 §§2-4
Essay is thin, one-​sided or unsupported	Development/​balance failure	basic/​07 §§5-6
Marks lost to agreement, preposition or punctuation	Usage failure	basic/​01-05; log the exact rule

Error log

Mock/​question	Error type	Exact wrong choice or sentence	Correct rule/​action	Re-​tested?

PART 04 - OFFICIAL-UPSC-SYLLABUS-MAPPING

Verbatim source: . . /OFFICIAL-UPSC-CSE-SYLLABUS-VERBATIM.md, “Qualifying Papers on Indian Languages and English”, lines 73-99. **FACT:** That source states the aim, the four English skill areas, Matriculation/equivalent standard, qualifying nature and non-ranking status. **ANALYSIS:** It does **not** itself establish a current qualifying percentage or marks threshold. That must be verified against the applicable annual notification.

Official clause	Core owner	Required proof of readiness
Comprehension of given passages	basic/​06_​Comprehension-​and-​Précis.md	Literal, inference, tone, purpose, title, reference, vocabulary-​in-​context and multipart answers under time
Precis Writing	basic/​06_​Comprehension-​and-​Précis.md	Idea map, proportion, count, paraphrase, coherence, concession and exact title instruction
Usage and Vocabulary	basic/​01 to basic/​05	Foundation test plus both full mocks
Short Essays	basic/​07_​Short-​Essay-​Writing.md	Choice, thesis, argument, counterargument, examples, revision and about-​600-​word control

All indispensable rules are in Core. Practice files test transfer; they are not the sole owner of a method.
00_Readiness-Tracker .md records performance and notification-verification status without turning either into an official UPSC claim.

PART 05 - ANSWER-WORTHINESS-AUDIT

Final status: FACT: Complete **Certification date:** 15 August 2026 **Standard:**
../.../ANSWER-WORTHINESS-AUDIT-STANDARD.md

1. Audit scope and inventory

- Seven mandatory Core owners:
 1. Parts of Speech;
 2. Sentence Grammar;
 3. Punctuation and Capitalisation;
 4. Vocabulary, Idioms and Proverbs;
 5. Error Correction and Transformation;
 6. Comprehension and Précis;
 7. Short Essay Writing.
- Master framework, README, official-syllabus map and readiness tracker.
- One 90-minute foundation diagnostic.
- Two independent three-hour, 300-mark full mocks with complete keys.
- Locally held compulsory-English papers for 2018, 2019, 2020, 2021, 2022, 2023 and 2025.
- Two hostile section audits followed by an independent whole-folder certification and regression gate.

2. Executive verdict

Qualifying English is **future-paper ready at Core level**. No Advanced folder is needed because all indispensable grammar, usage, comprehension, précis, vocabulary and essay methods are contained in the seven Core owners.

The final certification found:

- **7/7 Core owners passing;**
- **30/30 final score;**
- unfamiliar grammar, comprehension, précis and essay demands executable from Core;
 - an exact **180-minute** attempt plan;
 - one diagnostic plus two independent, fully keyed full mocks;
 - zero broken local Markdown links.

3. Ten-criterion scorecard

Criterion	Score	Certification basis
Demand fidelity	3	Core covers the four official clauses and the recurring forms in seven locally held papers.
Correct expression	3	Agreement, tense, case, reference, modifiers, punctuation and idiom are systematically controlled.
Method selection	3	Correction order, comprehension demand taxonomy, précis workflow and essay-choice matrix are operational.
Worked transfer	3	Every owner contains worked examples and unfamiliar diagnostic practice.
Vocabulary control	3	Confusables, spelling, derivation, register, idioms and accepted-use boundaries are integrated.
Comprehension fidelity	3	Literal, inferential, tone, purpose, title, reference and contextual-vocabulary demands are covered.
Précis discipline	3	Idea units, proportion, paraphrase, concession, title variants, recounting and one-third control are executable.
Essay execution	3	Selection, thesis, structure, evidence, balance, language, word count and revision support a 600-word response.
Timed-readiness safety	3	The 180-minute plan, section floors, error logs and two independent full mocks are explicit.
Factual-provenance discipline	3	Official syllabus facts, local-paper evidence, OCR defects and unverified threshold claims are separated.

Final score: 30/30.

4. Topic-by-topic matrix

Core owner	Result
01 Parts of Speech	PASS
02 Sentence Grammar	PASS
03 Punctuation and Capitalisation	PASS
04 Vocabulary, Idioms and Proverbs	PASS
05 Error Correction and Transformation	PASS
06 Comprehension and Précis	PASS
07 Short Essay Writing	PASS

Result: 7 PASS / 0 PARTIAL / 0 FAIL.

5. Future-question stress tests

The final gate successfully handled unfamiliar demands involving:

- count/non-count shifts, pronoun case and reference, modifiers and agreement;
- full tense/aspect control, mixed conditionals, determiners, prepositions and phrasal verbs;
- punctuation alternatives, spelling, derivation, confusables and register;
- active/passive voice, narration and exact meaning-preserving

transformations;

- literal, inferential, tone, purpose, title, reference and

vocabulary-in-context comprehension;

- multi-part answer allocation and evidence-linked concise responses;
- précis idea-unit selection, concession preservation, title/no-title

variants, paraphrase and exact length control;

- abstract and issue-based 600-word essays with qualified thesis, counterargument, safe examples and final revision.

6. Evidence-bank assessment

Demand family	Core evidence	Readiness
Grammar and correction	Rule/exception/accepted/variant grids, worked corrections and timed diagnostics	Ready
Vocabulary and usage	Confusables, morphology, spelling, idioms, proverbs and model sentences	Ready
Comprehension	Demand taxonomy, evidence extraction, mark allocation and worked responses	Ready
Précis	Idea/unit grids, source/model counts, paraphrase controls and scored models	Ready
Short essay	Choice matrix, thesis/outline tools, two complete models and anchored scoring	Ready

7. Factual-risk ledger

- The official syllabus confirms that the English paper is of matriculation-equivalent standard, qualifying only and excluded from ranking.
- The local official papers support a recurring three-hour, 300-mark structure with a 600-word essay, comprehension, one-third précis, and usage/vocabulary.
- The 2019 extraction reads 800 in its header; this is quarantined as an OCR defect because its section arithmetic and the other held papers support 300. The erroneous extraction is not repeated as a paper fact.
- $25\% = 75/300$ remains labelled ****unverified against the current official notification**** in this repository.
- $120/300$ is an explicitly **non-official internal safety target**.
- Accepted modern variants are distinguished from conservative examination house style rather than marked automatically wrong.

8. Core gaps repaired

- Expanded all grammar owners from summaries to rule, exception, variant, worked-example and timed-retry systems.
- Added count shifts, irregular nouns, singular *they*, restrictive relatives, mixed conditionals, determiner control, phrasal verbs, spelling, derivation and register.
- Rebuilt voice, narration and transformation with exact-meaning safeguards.
- Removed false absolutes about colons, double-object constructions and although/however.

- Replaced ambiguous diagnostic items and added explicit accepted-answer ranges.
- Corrected the attempt plan from 200 to exactly 180 minutes.
- Rebuilt comprehension around all major question directives.
- Added fully worked précis mapping, counting and one-third models.
- Added essay selection, thesis, counterargument, word-count and revision machinery plus two complete model essays.
- Corrected the dangling Being a holiday, the office... construction.
- Corrected Mock 1's précis record to **458 source words, approximately 153 target words and a 155-word model**.
- Removed model-overlap essay prompts from Mock 1.
- Made every free-response vocabulary and idiom item self-markable.
- Added a second independent full mock and key.

9. Safely skippable enrichment

No separate Advanced tier is required. Additional literary style, rare vocabulary or competitive creative-writing refinement may improve elegance, but none is necessary for the qualifying paper. Core already contains every paper-affecting method and readiness gate.

10. Files changed

- 00_Master-Framework.md
- README.md
- OFFICIAL-UPSC-SYLLABUS-MAPPING.md
- 00_Readiness-Tracker.md
- all seven files under basic/
- all three files under practice/
- all three files under answer-keys/
- this audit
- ../../../../ANSWER-WORTHINESS-REEVALUATION-TRACKER.md

11. Validation evidence

- Independent final certification: **PASS, 30/30**.
- Seven Core owners passed.
- Foundation diagnostic: **90 minutes** throughout.
- Two independent full mocks: **180 minutes and 300 marks each**.
- Mock 1 précis: **458 -> 155 words**.
- Mock 2 précis: **246 -> 83 words**.
- Two complete essay models: approximately **600 words each**.
- Local Markdown links: zero broken.
- Fenced blocks and inspected tables: structurally valid.

12. Final status

FACT: Complete - 15 August 2026.

PART 06 - 01 Parts-of-Speech

Use this file before basic/02_Sentence-Grammar .md. In correction questions, change only what is wrong; do not “improve” an already acceptable sentence.

1. Sentence map and word classes

determiner + adjective + NOUN/PRONOUN (subject) + finite VERB + object/complement

\ /
modifiers: adjective, adverb, phrase, clause

Class	Main job	Test
Noun	names a person, thing, quality or event	can often take a determiner/plural
Pronoun	replaces or points to a noun phrase	must have clear reference and case
Verb	expresses action, state or occurrence	finite verb changes for tense/agreement
Adjective	modifies a noun/pronoun	<i>a careful officer; officers are careful</i>
Adverb	modifies a verb, adjective, adverb or clause	<i>very careful; spoke carefully</i>
Determiner	identifies/quantifies a noun	<i>the, this, each, many, my</i>
Preposition	relates a noun phrase to another unit	<i>in Delhi; depend on evidence</i>
Conjunction	joins units	<i>and, although, because</i>

Words can change class: a **record** (*noun*); **record** the result (*verb*); an **early** train (*adjective*); arrive **early** (*adverb*).
Use function in the sentence, not a dictionary label.

2. Nouns: number and countability

Countable, uncountable and count shifts

Pattern	Safe use	Example
Singular count noun	needs a determiner	<i>a book; the proposal; my answer</i>
Plural count noun	takes <i>many/few/fewer</i>	<i>many books; fewer errors</i>
Uncountable/mass noun	no ordinary plural; takes <i>much/little/less</i>	<i>much information; little evidence</i>
Measure expression	makes an uncountable noun countable	<i>two pieces of advice; three items of equipment</i>
Count shift	meaning changes when a mass noun is counted	<i>paper</i> (material) / <i>a paper</i> (article); <i>experience</i> (knowledge) / <i>an experience</i> (event)

Common uncountables in examination corrections: **advice, information, furniture, equipment, luggage, baggage, scenery, research, progress, work, traffic, evidence, knowledge, machinery, bread, news.** Write a *piece of furniture, an item of information, a piece of evidence, some research.* News ends in -s but normally takes a singular verb: *The news is encouraging.*

Do not infer that every noun is permanently countable or uncountable:

Uncountable meaning	Countable meaning
<i>Chicken is expensive</i> (meat)	<i>three chickens</i> (birds)

Uncountable meaning	Countable meaning
<i>I need paper</i> (material)	<i>submit a paper</i> (essay/article)
<i>There is little room</i> (space)	<i>book a room</i> (place)
<i>Experience matters</i> (knowledge)	<i>it was a frightening experience</i> (event)
<i>Light travels quickly</i> (illumination)	<i>switch on the lights</i> (lamps)

Irregular, zero and plural-only nouns

Type	Examples	Agreement/use
Irregular plural	child/children, man/men, woman/women, foot/feet, tooth/teeth, mouse/mice, person/people	plural verb: <i>Children are...</i>
Same singular/plural	sheep, deer, aircraft, species, series	context decides: <i>one species is; two species are</i>
Noun ending in -s, singular	news, mathematics, economics (subject), politics (subject)	usually singular: <i>Economics is...</i>
Plural-only	scissors, trousers, spectacles, clothes, cattle, police	plural verb: <i>The police are...; a pair of scissors is...</i>
Collective noun	committee, team, government, family, jury	singular when viewed as one unit; plural when members act separately. Keep verb and pronoun consistent: <i>The committee has submitted its report</i> / <i>The committee are divided in their views.</i>

People is normally plural; persons is restricted to formal/legal counting. Data is commonly plural in careful academic prose (*the data are*), but singular collective *data is* occurs in modern general prose. Follow the question's register and remain consistent.

3. Pronouns: case, reference and agreement

Case

Function	Forms
Subject	I, we, he, she, they, who
Object of verb/preposition	me, us, him, her, them, whom
Possessive determiner	my, our, his, her, their, whose
Independent possessive	mine, ours, his, hers, theirs
Reflexive/emphatic	myself, yourself, himself, herself, itself, ourselves, yourselves, themselves

Use object case after a verb or preposition: *The officer called Riya and me; between you and me; whom did you meet?* In a comparison, supply the missing verb when needed: *She is taller than I (am); They invited her more often than me* is common but can be ambiguous. Write the full clause in a formal answer.

Reflexives need a same-clause antecedent or emphatic use: *She blamed herself; the director himself signed it.* Not Please contact myself; use me.

Reference, relatives and singular they

1. A pronoun must identify one sensible antecedent. Rewrite *When Ravi met Mohan, he was upset as Ravi was upset when he met Mohan*.
2. who is for people as subject; whom is object in formal style; whose shows possession; which normally refers to things; that may introduce a restrictive clause for people or things.
3. **Restrictive (identifying):** no commas. *Candidates who arrive late may not enter. **Non-restrictive (extra):** *commas and normally* who/which, *not* that. My brother, who lives in Pune, is a doctor.* Punctuation depends on intended meaning; it cannot be scored without context.
4. each, every, either, neither, everyone, someone, nobody normally take a singular verb: *Every applicant is ready*. Singular **they/them/their** is accepted modern formal English when sex is unknown or irrelevant: *Each applicant must bring their admit card*. A fully explicit alternative is *Each applicant must bring his or her admit card* or plural recasting: *Applicants must bring their admit cards*. Do not mark a clear singular they wrong merely for being singular.

4. Adjectives, determiners and adverbs

The usual adjective order is opinion -> size -> age -> shape -> colour -> origin -> material -> purpose -> noun: *a useful small old Indian wooden writing desk*. It is a preference, not a mechanical rule.

Point	Safe form
Comparison	<i>taller; more careful; the tallest; the most careful</i>
No double comparison	<i>more wiser -> wiser</i>
Comparison target	<i>prefer X to Y; senior/ junior/ superior/ inferior to</i>
Correlative comparison	<i>the more carefully you read, the better you write</i>
only placement	<i>Only Riya objected (nobody else); Riya objected only to the fee (nothing else)</i>
Fewer/less	<i>fewer books; less water</i> . <i>less than ten minutes</i> is accepted for quantity/time.

Some adverbs have the same form as adjectives: *fast, hard, late, early, daily*. *Hardly* means “scarcely,” not “with effort”: *work hard; hardly work*.

5. Verbs: form and transitivity

Pattern	Principal parts	Meaning check
rise	rise, rose, risen	something goes up itself
raise	raise, raised, raised	someone/something lifts another thing
lie (recline)	lie, lay, lain	<i>The child lay down yesterday</i>
lay (put)	lay, laid, laid	takes object: <i>She laid the file down</i>
fall	fall, fell, fallen	no object in ordinary use
fell	fell, felled, felled	cut down: <i>fell a tree</i>

Only verbs with an object normally form a passive: *The committee approved the plan -> The plan was approved*. Do not force a passive from *arrive, sleep, occur, happen*.

6. Fast diagnostic

Correct each, name the error code, then check below.

1. The police **is** investigating the case.
2. She gave me two useful **advices**.
3. Between you and I, the plan is unsafe.
4. Every candidate should bring **his** identity card.
5. The report **that** was published yesterday, changed the debate.
6. We bought two **furniture** for the office.

Key: 1 *are* [AGR]; 2 *pieces of advice* [CNT]; 3 *me* [PRO-CASE]; 4 *their* is accepted, or recast/pluralise [PRO-AGR]; 5 remove commas if identifying, or use *which* with commas if extra information [REL]; 6 *pieces of furniture* [CNT]. Time: **6 minutes**. Record every missed code in the error log in basic/05.

PART 07 - 02 Sentence-Grammar

1. Complete sentences and agreement

A complete sentence needs a finite verb and a complete thought. Repair a fragment (*Because the policy failed*) by attaching it to a main clause. Do not join two complete clauses with a comma alone: use a full stop, semicolon, or coordinating conjunction.

Subject pattern	Verb
singular noun/and pronoun	<i>The officer is ready.</i>
plural noun/and pronoun	<i>The officers are ready.</i>
each/and every/and either/and neither + singular noun	<i>Each proposal has merit.</i>
each of/and neither of + plural noun	formal default singular: <i>Neither of the alternatives is acceptable.</i> Plural is also common with <i>neither of</i> in modern use; use singular in a correction test unless context requires otherwise.
one of + plural noun	singular: <i>One of the answers is wrong.</i>
a number of /and the number of	plural /and singular: <i>A number are absent; the number is rising.</i>
amount, period, distance as one unit	singular: <i>Ten kilometres is far to walk.</i>
along with/and as well as/and together with	agrees with first subject: <i>The minister, along with officials, is attending.</i>
either...or/and neither...nor	normally agree with nearer subject: <i>Neither the officers nor the minister is ready.</i> Recast awkward mixed-and person subjects: <i>Neither the minister nor the officers are ready.</i>
collective noun	singular unit or plural members; keep pronoun consistent: <i>The team has its plan /and are arguing among themselves.</i>
none of + plural/and count noun	singular is traditional when "not one"; plural is common when "not any." Choose one form and keep the reference clear: <i>None of the evidence is...; none of the applicants are...</i>
fraction/and percentage + of	agree with the noun after of: <i>Half of the work is done; half of the files are missing.</i>
there is/and are	agree with the following real subject: <i>There are two errors; there is one error.</i>
gerund/and infinitive clause	usually singular: <i>Reading carefully is essential.</i>

More than one + singular noun normally takes singular (*More than one candidate has applied*). Many a + singular noun also takes singular.

2. Tense and aspect: choose the time relation

Meaning	Form	Example
fact, habit, timetable	simple present	<i>Water freezes at 0°C; the train leaves at six.</i>
action happening now/temporary arrangement	present continuous	<i>She is reading; they are staying in Delhi.</i>
completed action with present result; unfinished time	present perfect	<i>She has submitted the form; I have seen her today.</i>
duration continuing to now	present perfect continuous	<i>He has been working for five days.</i>
completed past at stated/finished time	simple past	<i>She submitted it yesterday; I saw her in 2024.</i>
ongoing past interrupted by another event	past continuous	<i>She was reading when I entered.</i>
earlier of two past points	past perfect	<i>The meeting had ended before we arrived. Use it for a needed sequence, not automatically for every past sentence.</i>
duration before a past point	past perfect continuous	<i>They had been waiting for an hour before the bus came.</i>
future prediction/decision	will + base verb	<i>I will call later.</i>
arranged future	present continuous	<i>We are meeting tomorrow.</i>
action in progress at future time	future continuous	<i>This time tomorrow, she will be travelling.</i>
future before a stated future point	future perfect	<i>By June, she will have finished.</i>
duration up to a future point	future perfect continuous	<i>By June, she will have been working here for a year.</i>

State verbs normally avoid continuous forms in their ordinary meanings: *know, believe, understand, own, belong, prefer, need*. Write *I know the rule*, not usually *I am knowing*. Some change meaning: *I think it is right* (opinion) / *I am thinking about it* (considering).

Time clauses and conditionals

Do not ordinarily put *will* after *if, when, until, as soon as, before* for a future condition: *If/when she arrives, I will call*. *Will* is possible when it means willingness: *If you will wait, I will check*.

Type	Form	Meaning/example
Zero	if + present, present	general result: <i>If water freezes, it expands.</i>
First	if + present, will/may/can/imperative	real future: <i>If you revise, you will improve.</i>
Second	if + past form, would/could/might + base	unreal present/future: <i>If I knew, I would tell you.</i> <i>were</i> is safest formal form: <i>If I were you...</i>
Third	if + past perfect, would/could/might have + past participle	unreal past: <i>If she had left earlier, she would have caught the train.</i>
Mixed: past condition, present result	if + past perfect, would + base	<i>If I had taken the job, I would live in Mumbai now.</i>

Type	Form	Meaning/​example
Mixed: present condition, past result	if + past form, would have + participle	<i>If he were more careful, he would not have made that error.</i>

Do not use *would* in the ordinary if-clause: *If I would know -> If I knew*. With *unless*, use an affirmative condition where it means *if ... not*: *Unless you practise, you will not improve*. Do **not** replace *if* with *unless* if it changes polarity, emphasis, or a negative main-clause meaning.

3. Articles and determiners

Article choice

Use	Example
a/​an = one, non-​specific singular count noun	<i>a university; an hour; an MBA graduate</i> - choose by sound, not spelling
the = specific, previously identified, unique in context, superlative/​ordinal	<i>the file you sent; the sun; the first answer; the best option</i>
zero article = plural/​uncountable in general	<i>Books are useful; Honesty matters; Water is scarce.</i>
institution purpose	<i>go to school/&#8203;prison/&#8203;hospital</i> as pupil/​prisoner/​patient; <i>go to the school/&#8203;hospital</i> as a building/​visitor
geographical names	<i>India, Delhi, Mount Everest</i> ; but <i>the Himalayas, the Ganga, the Indian Ocean, the United States</i>

A singular count noun normally cannot stand bare: *She is teacher* -> *She is a teacher*. General abstract nouns can take *the* when qualified: *Freedom is valuable; the freedom guaranteed by law matters*.

Determiners and quantity

Count nouns	Uncountable nouns	Either/​other
many, few/​a few, fewer, several	much, little/​a little, less	some, any, enough, more, most, all, no

few/little means hardly any; *a few/a little* means some and is positive. Use *fewer candidates* but *less water*; *less than ten candidates* is common in measurement-style usage but *fewer* is safest in formal correction. *much* is common in negatives/questions; *a great deal of* is natural in positive statements. Use *some* in offers/requests expecting yes: *Would you like some tea?*

Determiner contrast	Safe use
each/​every	both take singular noun and verb; <i>each</i> views individuals, <i>every</i> the group: <i>Every room; each of the rooms</i>
either/​neither	normally one of/​not one of two: <i>either answer is; neither answer is</i>
both	plural: <i>both answers are</i>
another/​other/​the other	one more; additional/​different; the remaining one of two: <i>another book; other books; the other book</i>
fewer/​less	number of countable items; amount/​quantity
amount/​number	uncountable quantity; countable items: <i>amount of water; number of books</i>

4. Prepositions, verb patterns and phrasal verbs

Memorise the whole construction. A preposition may vary with meaning; do not invent a universal rule from one example.

Meaning	Safe construction
agree with a person /​ agree to a plan /​ agree on a point	<i>I agree with her; they agreed to the proposal.</i>
angry with/​at a person; angry at/​about an act	Both <i>angry with the contractor</i> and <i>angry at the contractor</i> are standard.
approve of; comply with; consist of; depend on; insist on	<i>comply with the order; insist on verification</i>
abstain from; distinguish X from Y; responsible for	<i>abstain from voting</i>
discuss/​enter/​approach/​reach	no about /​ into /​ to in ordinary transitive use: <i>discuss the proposal; enter a room; approach the officer; reach Delhi</i>
comprise /​ consist	<i>The unit comprises five sections; The unit consists of five sections.</i> Avoid <i>comprises of</i> in formal correction.
wait for; listen to; belong to; suffer from	<i>wait for a bus; listen to advice</i>

Double objects and provide

Many verbs allow two patterns:

Verb	Pattern 1	Pattern 2
give/​send/​show/ ​teach	<i>give her the file</i>	<i>give the file to her</i>
buy/​make/​find	<i>buy her a book</i>	<i>buy a book for her</i>
provide	<i>provide students with meals</i>	<i>provide meals for/&#8203;to students</i>

Provide someone something is established, especially in North American usage, but is less preferred in conservative British formal prose. It is not a grammar error. In an Indian formal correction answer, prefer one of the two standard provide ... with/for/to patterns unless the question tests a stated house style.

Phrasal/prepositional verbs

Verb	Meaning	Example
look after	care for	<i>look after children</i>
look for	seek	<i>look for evidence</i>
look into	investigate	<i>look into the complaint</i>
look up to	admire	<i>look up to her teacher</i>
put off	postpone	<i>put off the meeting</i>
put up with	tolerate	<i>put up with noise</i>
carry out	perform	<i>carry out an inquiry</i>
bring up	mention/​raise	<i>bring up the issue</i>
turn down	reject/​reduce	<i>turn down the offer</i>
take over	assume control	<i>take over the office</i>

Separable verb + pronoun: *turn the offer down / turn it down*, not *turn down it*. Do not split inseparable *look after*: *look the child after* is wrong.

5. Conjunctions, parallelism and modifiers

Rule	Correct form
No double conjunction	<i>Although it rained, we left</i> ; not <i>Although... but...</i>
because gives reason; because of takes noun phrase	<i>because it rained</i> ; <i>because of rain</i>
despite/ ; in spite of takes noun phrase or <i>the fact that</i> clause	<i>despite the rain</i> ; <i>in spite of the fact that it rained</i>
not only...but also needs matched units	<i>not only honest but also efficient</i> ; <i>not only reads but also writes</i>
either...or ; neither...nor ; both...and	match grammar on both sides: <i>either to revise or to withdraw</i> ; <i>both accurate and concise</i>
paired list stays parallel	<i>planning, coordinating and monitoring</i>
comparison compares like with like	<i>the population of Delhi is larger than that of Pune</i>

Place a modifier beside its target:

Fault	Repair
Dangling: <i>Walking to office, the rain began.</i>	<i>While I was walking to office, it began to rain.</i>
Misplaced: <i>She served sandwiches to the children on paper plates.</i>	<i>She served the children sandwiches on paper plates.</i>
Squinting: <i>Students who regularly revise improve.</i>	Place <i>regularly</i> beside the intended verb: <i>Students who revise regularly improve.</i>

6. Timed diagnostic

In **10 minutes**, correct and label:

1. A number of applicant is absent.
2. If I would have known, I would have called.
3. She has finished the report yesterday.
4. He went to hospital to visit his friend.
5. Neither the manager nor the clerks is ready.
6. We discussed about how to put up with the delay.
7. The office provided the workers meals.
8. Although he was tired but he worked.
9. Having read the report, the errors were obvious.
10. She turned down it.

Key: 1 *applicants are* [AGR]; 2 *had known* [COND]; 3 *finished* [TNS]; 4 *the hospital* [ART]; 5 *are* [AGR]; 6 *discussed how to put up with...* [PREP]; 7 *accepted, though provided the workers with meals* is safest [VAR]; 8 remove *but* [CONJ]; 9 *Having read the report, I found the errors obvious* [MOD]; 10 *turned it down* [PHR].

PART 08 - 03 Punctuation-and-Capitalisation

Punctuation clarifies structure. In a correction question, preserve the intended meaning and accept more than one standard punctuation choice where context permits it.

1. Commas

Use	Example
items in a series	<i>data, staff, finance and time</i>
introductory phrase/;​clause	<i>After the meeting, we left.</i>
two complete clauses joined by <i>and, but, or, so, yet</i>	<i>The proposal was sound, but funding was absent.</i>
non-​restrictive information	<i>The chairperson, who arrived late, apologised.</i>
direct address /​ answer	<i>Riya, please read; No, I disagree.</i>
contrast	<i>The decision was legal, not wise.</i>

The serial/Oxford comma before *and* is a style choice: *data, staff, finance, and time* and *data, staff, finance and time* are both standard. Use it when it prevents ambiguity and stay consistent.

Do **not** put a comma:

- between subject and verb: The causes of pollution, are...;
- between verb and object: The committee submitted, its report;
- around an identifying/restrictive relative clause: *Students who practise regularly improve*;
- alone between two complete clauses (a comma splice): `The plan failed, we revised it`.

Repair a comma splice with a full stop, semicolon, colon where appropriate, or a comma plus a coordinating conjunction. Context decides whether a relative clause is essential; a sentence such as *My brother who lives in Pune...* cannot be punctuated uniquely without knowing whether the writer has other brothers.

2. Semicolon, colon and dash

Mark	Safe use	Example
semicolon	joins closely linked independent clauses; separates complex list items	<i>Evidence was incomplete; the inquiry continued.</i>
colon	introduces explanation, list, restatement or quotation after a complete lead-​in	<i>The paper tests four abilities: comprehension, précis, usage and essay writing.</i>
dash	interruption, sharp addition or emphasis	<i>One point remained-the evidence was weak.</i>

Avoid a colon that merely splits a verb or preposition from its necessary object: The abilities are: grammar and usage is usually better as *The abilities are grammar and usage* or *The abilities are as follows: grammar and usage*. This is a **style and clarity preference, not an absolute grammar ban**. A colon can follow a complete clause ending in a verb where the clause genuinely announces what follows: *Her conclusion was clear: postpone the launch.*

3. Apostrophes, quotation and terminal marks

Use	Example
singular possession	<i>the candidate's answer</i>
regular plural possession	<i>the candidates' answers</i>
irregular plural possession	<i>children's books</i>
contraction	<i>don't; it's (= it is/it has)</i>
possessive its	<i>The committee submitted its report.</i>

Never use an apostrophe for an ordinary plural: NGO 's -> NGOs. An apostrophe after a joint possession goes on the final name: *Ravi and Mohan's office*; separate ownership takes both: *Ravi's and Mohan's offices*.

Use quotation marks for exact speech. Direct speech normally has a reporting comma: *The minister said, "We must act now."* In indirect speech remove quotation marks and adjust grammar. British and US placement of a final full stop relative to quotation marks can differ; follow the paper's style unless the quoted words themselves require it.

End statements with a full stop. Use ? only for a direct question: *He asked whether I was ready*. Avoid ! in a formal answer except when quoting.

4. Hyphens, brackets and ellipsis

- Hyphenate a compound modifier before a noun: *a well-written answer; a five-year plan. *Do not usually hyphenate after the verb*: the answer is well written; the plan is five years old*.
- Do not hyphenate an adverb ending in -ly: *a carefully written answer*.
- Brackets add non-essential clarification. Use sparingly in formal prose.
- An ellipsis shows omitted words in a quotation; it is not a substitute for planning a sentence.

5. Capitalisation

Capitalise the first word of a sentence, proper names, languages/nationalities, days/months, named institutions, Acts and formally used titles: *India, English, Monday, the Constitution of India, Parliament, the President of India*. Use lower case for generic roles: *the minister spoke; a parliamentary committee met*. Capitalisation does not make a common noun important.

6. Punctuation decision path

Two complete clauses?

- + joined by coordinating conjunction -> comma + conjunction
- + closely related without conjunction -> semicolon or full stop
- + second explains first -> colon (if first clause is complete)

Relative clause?

- + identifies which person/thing -> no commas
- + adds removable information -> pair of commas

7. Timed diagnostic

Punctuate in **7 minutes**; state an accepted alternative where relevant.

1. after the interview we returned home
2. the proposal was ambitious however it lacked funding
3. the reports that were incomplete were returned
4. my only brother who lives in pune is a doctor
5. the inquiry had one conclusion postpone the launch

6. its important to check every candidates identity card

Key: 1 *After the interview, we returned home.* [PUNC]; 2 *The proposal was ambitious; however, it lacked funding.* A full stop before *however* is also accepted [PUNC]; 3 *The reports that were incomplete were returned.* [REL]; 4 *My only brother, who lives in Pune, is a doctor.* [REL/CAP]; 5 *The inquiry had one conclusion: postpone the launch.* [COL]; 6 *It's important to check every candidate's identity card.* [APOS].

PART 09 - 04 Vocabulary-Idioms-and-Proverbs

Vocabulary questions test exact meaning, grammar and register. A “use in a sentence” answer earns credit only if the context makes the intended sense unmistakable.

1. Learn a word as a usable entry

For every new word record:

headword | part of speech | plain meaning | common collocation
one near-synonym | one contrast/antonym | one original formal sentence

Example: **mitigate** (verb): make less severe; *mitigate a risk*; near synonym *alleviate*; contrast *aggravate*. *Early warning systems mitigate flood risk; they do not eliminate it.*

A synonym is rarely interchangeable in every setting. Childish and childlike both relate to a child, but the first is usually disapproving and the second often approving. Prefer a plain accurate word to an impressive near-synonym with the wrong register.

Register	Prefer	Avoid when formality needs precision
formal neutral	<i>assist, obtain, demonstrate, purchase</i>	<i>casual help out, get hold of, show off, buy up</i>
precise contrast	<i>economic</i> (economy) /​ <i>economical</i> (not wasteful)	treating them as synonyms
intensity	<i>alleviate</i> (reduce) /​ <i>eradicate</i> (remove completely)	claiming eradication when only reduction occurred

2. Confusables and collocations

Word 1	Word 2	Distinction/​example
accept	except	receive/​agree; excluding
advice (noun)	advise (verb)	<i>give advice; advise a candidate</i>
affect (usually verb)	effect (usually noun; also verb = bring about)	<i>affect outcomes; have an effect; effect change</i>
all ready	already	fully prepared; by now
altar	alter	religious table; change
appraise	apprise	assess value; inform: <i>apprise her of</i>
assure	ensure	reassure a person; make certain an outcome
complement	compliment	complete; praise
conscience	conscious	moral sense; aware
credible	credulous	believable; too ready to believe
discreet	discrete	tactful/​unobtrusive; separate
economic	economical	relating to economy; saving money
eminent	imminent	distinguished; about to happen

Word 1	Word 2	Distinction/example
farther	further	physical distance; additional/abstract (modern use overlaps)
principal	principle	chief/head or capital sum; rule
stationery	stationary	writing material; not moving
than	then	comparison; time/result
their/there/they're	possession/place/they are	<i>their files are there; they're ready</i>
who's	whose	who is/who has; possession
climatic	climactic	climate-related; relating to climax

3. Spelling: patterns, not guesses

Pattern	Rule	Examples /caution
-able/-ible/-ible	no fully reliable sound rule; learn word families	<i>reliable, manageable; visible, permissible</i>
final silent e	usually drop before vowel suffix; retain before consonant suffix	<i>making, hopeful; hoped, safely</i>
y after consonant	change y to i before most suffixes, but not -ing	<i>carry -> carried; happy -> happier; carry -> carrying</i>
doubled final consonant	one stressed vowel + one consonant before vowel suffix	<i>admit -> admitted; prefer -> preferred; travel -> travelled/traveled</i>
-cede/-ceed/-sede	-ceed mainly <i>proceed, exceed, succeed</i>	<i>precede, recede; supersede</i>

High-frequency spellings to retrieve exactly: **accommodate, accommodation, achievement, argument, calendar, committee, definitely, discipline, embarrass, environment, government, independent, maintenance, necessary, noticeable, occurrence, privilege, receive, recommend, separate, successful, tomorrow**. British and American variants may both be correct when used consistently: *colour/color, organisation/organization, travelled/traveled*.

4. Word formation and grammatical fit

Identify the required part of speech from the slot before choosing a related word. A verb after to is base form; an adjective commonly follows a linking verb; a noun commonly follows a determiner or possessive.

Base	Noun	Verb	Adjective	Adverb
decide	decision	decide	decisive	decisively
succeed	success	succeed	successful	successfully
explain	explanation	explain	explanatory	-
benefit	benefit	benefit	beneficial	beneficially
differ	difference	differ	different	differently
govern	government	govern	governmental	-
create	creation	create	creative	creatively
approve	approval	approve	approved/approving	-

Common negative prefixes are not freely interchangeable: *inaccurate, illegal, impossible, irregular, non-essential*. Learn the completed word. Common suffix signals: -tion/-ment/-ness (noun), -ify/-ise/-ize (verb), -ful/-less/-ive/-al (adjective), -ly (often adverb). Check meaning: economic is not the same as economical, and historic is not the same as historical.

5. Synonyms, antonyms and definition questions

Give an antonym of the same grammatical class unless the question says otherwise: *scarce* -> *abundant*; *rigid* -> *flexible*; *temporary* -> *permanent*; *transparent* -> *opaque*; *voluntary* -> *compulsory*. Several answers can be valid when they preserve the required sense. For a one-word question, a key must state an accepted set or accept a defensible equivalent; do not demand one dictionary synonym where the stem gives no context.

For “use in a sentence,” show the word’s exact sense:

Word	Weak	Creditworthy
impartial	<i>The judge was impartial.</i>	<i>The impartial judge heard both sides before giving reasons.</i>
feasible	<i>The plan is feasible.</i>	<i>The engineer showed that the bridge was feasible within the approved budget.</i>
reluctant	<i>She was reluctant.</i>	<i>Reluctant to sign without evidence, she asked for the full report.</i>

6. Idioms and proverbs

An idiom has a conventional non-literal meaning; a proverb states a general lesson. Use an idiom grammatically and a proverb only where it supports the point.

Expression	Meaning	Natural use
at sea	confused/uncertain	<i>Without the map, I was at sea.</i>
a thorn in the flesh	persistent irritation/problem	<i>The leak became a thorn in the administration's flesh.</i>
move heaven and earth	make every possible effort	<i>Officials moved heaven and earth to restore supply.</i>
step into someone's shoes	take over a role	<i>She stepped into her predecessor's shoes.</i>
know the ins and outs	know all details	<i>The clerk knows the ins and outs of the process.</i>
cut adrift	abandon or leave unsupported/isolated	<i>Small suppliers were cut adrift when credit stopped.</i>
cut corners	save time/money improperly by lowering standards	<i>The contractor cut corners on safety.</i>
a blessing in disguise	apparent misfortune later proves beneficial	<i>The delay was a blessing in disguise because it exposed the defect.</i>
A stitch in time saves nine.	early action prevents a bigger problem	-
Look before you leap.	consider consequences first	-
Actions speak louder than words.	conduct is stronger evidence than promises	-
All that glitters is not gold.	appearance can mislead	-

Mock-usage expressions

- **go berserk** - an informal verb phrase meaning *to become violently

uncontrollable or behave wildly, *often from extreme anger, fear or excitement. Use it intransitively: a person/crowd goes, went, has gone berserk; do not use it for ordinary annoyance or as a transitive verb.* When the alarm malfunctioned, the frightened crowd went berserk and staff called for help.*

- **Where there is a will, there is a way.** - a fixed proverb meaning that

determined effort and resolve can help a person find a solution. Use the complete sentence (or quote it); it is a motivating generalisation, not a guarantee that every obstacle can be overcome. *After the student mastered typing through persistent practice, her teacher said, "Where there is a will, there is a way."*

7. Acquisition and timed retrieval

Use a **5-10-1** cycle: learn five entries, test after ten minutes without looking, then use each once in a sentence the next day. Keep a two-column log: word confused -> contrast and corrected sentence. Do not rely on rereading.

In **8 minutes**, supply the requested form or choice:

1. The measure may ____ hardship. (alleviate/alleviation)
2. The committee reached a ____ after debate. (decide/decision)
3. The officer acted ____ during negotiations. (discreet/discrete)
4. The storm did not ____ the inland district. (affect/effect)
5. Correct: *The accomodation was definately insufficient.*
6. Give an antonym of *scarce*.
7. Use *cut corners* in a sentence.

Key: 1 *alleviate* [WF]; 2 *decision* [WF]; 3 *discreet* [CONF]; 4 *affect* [CONF]; 5 *The accommodation was definitely insufficient.* [SPL]; 6 *abundant* (also *plentiful* in suitable context) [SYN]; 7 must mean improperly reducing standards to save resources [IDIOM].

PART 10 - 05 Error-Correction-and-Transformation

1. Correction method and error codes

Read for meaning first, then scan in this order:

finite verb/agreement -> tense/conditional -> noun/determiner -> pronoun
-> verb pattern/preposition -> word form/spelling -> modifier/parallelism -> punctuation

Make the smallest change that restores standard formal English. Do not mark an accepted modern variant wrong merely because a traditional alternative exists.

Code	Check
AGR	agreement/number
CNT	countability/determiner
PRO	pronoun case, reference or agreement
TNS	tense/aspect
COND	conditional/polarity
ART	article/determiner
PREP	preposition or verb pattern
PHR	phrasal-verb position/meaning
MOD	misplaced/dangling modifier

Code	Check
PAR	parallel structure
PUNC	punctuation/;capital
SPL	spelling/;confusable
WF	word form
VAR	acceptable-/;variant issue

2. Frequent correction families

Fault	Safe correction
One of the applicant have...	<i>One of the applicants has...</i> [AGR/;CNT]
furnitures/;informations	<i>furniture/;information</i> or a measure phrase [CNT]
She is senior than me	<i>senior to me</i> [PREP]
He discussed about the proposal	<i>discussed the proposal</i> [PREP]
I have been waiting since three hours	<i>for three hours</i> [PREP]
When I will arrive...	<i>When I arrive...</i> [TNS]
comprises of	<i>comprises /; consists of</i> [PREP]
look at children (care for)	<i>look after children</i> [PHR]
more wiser	<i>wiser</i> [WF]
The woodcutter was falling trees	<i>was felling trees</i> [WF]

The reason is because funding was delayed occurs in modern English, but some conservative examination keys reject it as redundant. To avoid a marking dispute, write *The reason is that funding was delayed* or *Funding was delayed because....* A key must not present the original as objectively ungrammatical without stating its house style [VAR].

3. Voice: preserve tense, object and meaning

Only a verb that has an object normally makes a passive. Move the object to subject position; keep tense, aspect, modal and relevant adverbials.

Active	Passive
<i>They write reports.</i>	<i>Reports are written.</i>
<i>They are writing a report.</i>	<i>A report is being written.</i>
<i>They wrote a report.</i>	<i>A report was written.</i>
<i>They had written a report.</i>	<i>A report had been written.</i>
<i>They have written a report.</i>	<i>A report has been written.</i>
<i>They will write a report.</i>	<i>A report will be written.</i>
<i>They can/;must write a report.</i>	<i>A report can/;must be written.</i>

Double objects, questions and imperatives

Active	Accepted passive(s)
<i>The board gave Riya a prize.</i>	<i>Riya was given a prize. / A prize was given to Riya.</i>
<i>Someone has sent me the file.</i>	<i>I have been sent the file. / The file has been sent to me.</i>
<i>Did the officer sign the order?</i>	<i>Was the order signed by the officer?</i>
<i>Who wrote the letter?</i>	<i>By whom was the letter written? (formal)</i>
<i>Open the door.</i>	<i>Let the door be opened. (formal, often unnatural)</i>
<i>Do not disturb the patient.</i>	<i>Let the patient not be disturbed.</i>

Omit by + agent when unknown, obvious or irrelevant: *The accused was arrested*. Do not force passive with intransitives (*arrive, occur, sleep*) or verbs that do not take the intended object. Prepositional passives are possible where the preposition belongs to the verb: *The proposal was approved of* is grammatical but often awkward; *The children were looked after* is natural.

4. Direct and indirect speech (narration)

First identify speaker, listener, reporting time and exact communicative purpose. Pronouns, time/place words and tense change only when the new context requires it.

Direct form	Indirect pattern
statement: <i>He said, "I am tired."</i>	<i>He said (that) he was tired.</i>
yes/no question: <i>She asked, "Are you ready?"</i>	<i>She asked whether/if I was ready.</i>
wh-question: <i>He asked, "Where do you live?"</i>	<i>He asked where I lived.</i>
command: <i>The officer said, "Close the door."</i>	<i>The officer ordered me to close the door.</i>
request: <i>She said to me, "Please wait."</i>	<i>She asked me to wait.</i>
negative command: <i>He said, "Do not move."</i>	<i>He told us not to move.</i>

In formal reported speech, a past reporting verb commonly backshifts: am/is -> was; are -> were; have/has done -> had done; did -> had done; will -> would; can -> could. Backshift is not automatic when the fact remains true, the report is immediate, or the writer deliberately keeps present relevance: *The teacher said that the Earth moves around the Sun*. Universal truths normally remain present. Do not change a question into question word order: He asked where did I live -> *He asked where I lived*. Said to is usually replaced by a purpose verb (*asked, told, advised, ordered*) in commands.

5. Meaning-preserving transformations: conditions first

A transformation is correct only if time, polarity, emphasis, agent and scope remain the same. These are patterns, not automatic substitutions.

Original and condition	Safe transformation
<i>As soon as the bell rang, students left</i> (past)	<i>No sooner had the bell rung than the students left.</i>
past event immediately followed by another	<i>Hardly/Scarcely had the rain stopped when/before work resumed.</i>
if ... not with equivalent positive condition	<i>Unless you practise, you will not improve.</i>
so + adjective + that + subject cannot/could not + verb	<i>too + adjective + for + object + to + verb: The box is too heavy for me to lift.</i>

Original and condition	Safe transformation
<i>although + clause</i>	<i>In spite of/;&#8203;despite + noun phrase or in spite of/;&#8203;despite the fact that + clause: Despite being tired, he worked.</i>
two positive parallel facts	<i>He is not only honest but also efficient.</i>
two negative qualities of same subject	<i>She is neither careless nor dishonest.</i>
purpose	<i>He worked hard so that he could qualify /;&#8203; in order to qualify (same subject only)</i>
comparative degree	<i>No other metal is as useful as iron -> Iron is the most useful metal (only when the comparison set is unchanged)</i>
only scope	<i>Only Meera checked the accounts -> Meera checked only the accounts</i> changes focus from actor to object; use only when that exact changed focus is requested.

Do not use an alleged *although* -> *however* + adjective/adverb formula. *However* is a conjunctive adverb and normally joins independent clauses: *The task was difficult; however, she completed it.* It cannot simply replace *although* at the start of a dependent clause.

Being + adjective/past participle must modify the grammatical subject: *Being flooded, the road was closed* is valid. *Being a holiday, the office was closed* dangles because an office is not a holiday. Use *As it was a holiday, the office was closed* or the formal absolute *It being a holiday, the office was closed*.

6. Question tags

Statement	Tag
<i>They will come</i>	<i>won't they?</i>
<i>She is not ready</i>	<i>is she?</i>
<i>I am late</i>	<i>aren't I?</i>
<i>Let's begin</i>	<i>shall we?</i>
<i>Open the door</i>	<i>will you?</i>
<i>Don't be late</i>	<i>will you?</i>
<i>There is a problem</i>	<i>isn't there?</i>

Use the auxiliary already present; use *do/does/did* when none appears.

7. Timed mixed diagnostic and retry gate

Attempt without notes in **15 minutes**:

- Convert: *Someone has offered the students scholarships.*
- Report: *The teacher said to Riya, "Please do not leave early."*
- Report: *The guide said, "The Earth moves around the Sun."*
- Transform without changing meaning: **Although the roads were flooded, the buses continued.**
- Begin with *Unless*: *If you do not submit the form, you cannot sit the test.*
- Correct: *Being a holiday, the office was closed.*
- Correct: *No sooner the train arrived than we boarded it.*
- Add a tag: *Let us revise the answer, ____?*
- Correct: *The manager gave to Riya the file.*

10. Correct only if necessary: *Each candidate must bring their admit card.*

Key: 1 *The students have been offered scholarships / Scholarships have been offered to the students* [VOICE]; 2 *The teacher asked/told Riya not to leave early* [NAR]; 3 *The guide said that the Earth moves around the Sun* [NAR]; 4 *Despite/In spite of the flooded roads, the buses continued or Despite/In spite of the fact that the roads were flooded...* [TRN]; 5 *Unless you submit the form, you cannot sit the test* [COND]; 6 *As it was a holiday...* [MOD]; 7 *No sooner had the train arrived than...* [TNS]; 8 *shall we?* [TAG]; 9 *The manager gave Riya the file / gave the file to Riya* [VAR]; 10 no change required; singular *their* is accepted [VAR].

Retry gate: score at least **9/10**, with no COND, VOICE, NAR or VAR error. If not, log item number, code, wrong rule and corrected sentence; wait one day, then complete a fresh mixed set from the Foundation test. Do not move to full-paper practice until two consecutive timed attempts meet this gate.

PART 11 - 06 Comprehension-and-Precis

1. Comprehension: read the demand before answering

Question command -> locate evidence -> identify answer type
-> list every requested limb -> answer in own concise words
-> check against passage, not outside knowledge

Demand	What it asks	Safe answer move	Common failure
Literal	Explicitly stated fact/reason	State the relevant claim and its stated reason	Copying an entire paragraph
Inferential	What follows from two or more clues	State the conclusion, then name the textual clues	Treating a plausible opinion as evidence
Tone/attitude	Author's stance, not topic	Use a precise adjective plus two language/idea signals	"The tone is about pollution"
Purpose	Why the author uses an example/contrast	State its function in the argument	Retelling the example
Title	Central organising claim	Give a short title and justify it with coverage	Choosing a decorative phrase
Reference	What <i>this/it/they/such</i> denotes	Name the nearest logical antecedent and test the sentence	Naming the nearest noun mechanically
Vocabulary in context	Meaning in this passage	Give a context-fitting synonym and explain its local sense	Dictionary meaning that conflicts with context
Multipart	Two or more asked elements	Number or separate all limbs; allocate space to each	Answering only the first limb

Command decoder

Wording	Deliverable
Why/how	Cause or mechanism, not merely result
Explain	Meaning plus the passage's support
Distinguish	At least two contrasted bases
What does the author mean by...	Paraphrase the phrase and connect it to context
Comment/critically observe	A qualified inference anchored in the passage
Enumerate	All major listed points, compressed and complete

Multi-part allocation rule

Circle **every** noun joined by *and*, *or*, commas or a semicolon. Make a micro-plan before writing:

"What financial and institutional causes ..., and what follows?"

financial cause(s)		institutional cause(s)		consequence
5 marks		5 marks		5 marks

The split printed in a practice key is a coaching diagnostic, not an official UPSC marking scheme. For a 15-mark response, give one compact, supported unit for every requested limb before adding explanation.

2. Answer calibration

- Answer from the passage even if outside knowledge differs.
- Use complete sentences unless the question specifically asks for a list.
- Start with the answer, not "The author says that...".
- For an inference, use calibrated language: *suggests*, *implies*, *indicates*.
- Quote only a crucial word or phrase; paraphrase the rest.
- A title answer needs both a title and a one-sentence justification if the question asks for either.
- If the question asks for tone, do not call a serious argument "sad" or "informative"; identify the stance: *cautious*, *critical*, *qualified*, *ironic*, *approving*, *sceptical*.

3. Worked comprehension diagnostic

Passage

Many municipal offices have begun to publish the number of complaints they close each week. The practice can expose neglect, but it can also mislead. A complaint may be marked closed when an officer has sent an automatic reply, transferred it to another department or asked the citizen to submit the same document again. Such actions may be necessary at times, yet they do not show that the underlying problem has been solved.

The useful question is therefore not simply how quickly a file leaves a desk. It is whether the service becomes usable. A streetlight is not repaired because a message has been acknowledged; it is repaired when it works. This distinction matters especially to people who cannot repeatedly visit an office, make phone calls during working hours or pay a private provider. Public data should consequently record both the first response and the final outcome. Otherwise, an impressive dashboard may reward administrative movement while concealing public inaction.

Questions

1. Why can a high complaint-closure number be misleading? **(4)**
2. What distinction does the streetlight example make? **(3)**
3. What does "administrative movement" mean in context? **(3)**
4. Infer the author's attitude to dashboards that report only closures. Give two grounds from the passage. **(3 + 2)**
5. Give a suitable title and justify it in one sentence. **(3)**

Key with diagnostic splits

1. It may record an automatic reply, transfer or repeat-document request **(2)** even though the underlying service failure remains unsolved **(2)**.
2. It separates acknowledging a complaint **(1)** from fixing the actual service **(2)**.
3. It means procedural handling of a file-replying, transferring or recording it-without necessarily delivering a solution **(3)**.
4. The author is **critical but qualified (1)**: dashboards can expose neglect **(1)**, but closure-only reporting may reward activity rather than outcomes **(1)**. Any two grounded signals earn the evidence marks **(2)**.
5. "**Closure Is Not Repair**" **(1)** is suitable because the passage contrasts recorded disposal with a usable public service **(2)**.

4. Précis: preserve the argument, not the surface

A précis is an accurate, coherent compression of the whole passage to the instructed proportion, normally about one-third in the local paper samples.

Read twice -> mark thesis / idea units / concession / conclusion
-> calculate target -> remove illustration and repetition
-> paraphrase -> connect -> count -> obey title instruction

Idea-unit map

Passage unit	Keep?	Why /​ treatment
Thesis or central tension	Always	Opens the précis
Major reason, mechanism or consequence	Usually	One compressed sentence per major unit
Concession (<i>although, yet, while</i>)	Usually	Preserve the author's qualification
Example, name, quotation, rhetorical question	Usually remove	Retain only if it carries an irreplaceable distinction
Repetition, decoration, minor detail	Remove	Does not change argument
Final recommendation/​verdict	Always	Close the précis

Explicit word-count method

1. Count the source's space-separated words for practice; count a hyphenated form as one word and do not count a title.
2. Divide by the instructed ratio. For one-third, a 360-word source gives a target of about 120 words.
3. Record **source -> target -> final** on rough work.
4. "About" is not a published tolerance. For this kit's practice, aim within roughly 10% of the calculated target; if the paper gives a number or tolerance, that instruction overrides this coaching convention.
5. Count the final draft again after revision. Do not cut a central concession merely to reach the number.

Paraphrase and coherence controls

- Change the sentence structure as well as isolated words.
- Retain technical terms where replacing them would reduce accuracy.
- Use indirect speech for a quoted claim.
- Keep the author's order unless rearrangement clearly improves logic.
- Link units with logical connectors: *however, therefore, consequently, although*.
- Do not add opinion, an example, a moral or a title that the instruction forbids.

Title-instruction variants

Instruction	Action
"Do not give a title"	Write no heading at all.
"Do not give or suggest a title"	Write no heading and do not embed a title-​like label.
"Give a suitable title"	Supply a short, accurate organising phrase after drafting; do not spend words on ornament.
No title instruction	Follow the exact paper wording; do not assume a title is rewarded.

5. Worked précis: idea units, proportion and concession

Source passage

Online meetings have made it easier for organisations to assemble people who live far apart. They can reduce travel, allow a specialist to join briefly and create a written record of decisions. These advantages explain why a video link is now often treated as a complete substitute for physical presence.

That conclusion is too simple. A meeting does more than transmit information. Participants notice hesitation, continue a discussion after the formal agenda and form informal relationships that make later cooperation easier. Digital meetings can reproduce some of these functions, especially when participants already know one another and the task is narrowly defined. They are less reliable when a group must build trust, settle a sensitive disagreement or learn a complex skill together.

The choice should therefore depend on the purpose rather than on fashion. Organisations should use online meetings for routine coordination, while protecting occasional in-person work for tasks requiring trust, observation and sustained collaboration. The goal is not to reject technology, but to use it without pretending that all forms of presence are identical.

Idea-unit map

Unit	Retain in model
Online meetings widen access and reduce travel	Yes
They are often treated as a full substitute	Yes
Meetings also build trust and informal cooperation	Yes
Digital works for known groups/narrow tasks but not all tasks	Yes, as concession
Purpose-based mixed use is the verdict	Yes

Model précis

Online meetings reduce travel and widen access, so they are often treated as substitutes for physical meetings. However, meetings build trust and informal cooperation. Digital formats suit known groups handling limited tasks but are less dependable for disputes, complex learning or new relationships. Organisations should choose the format by purpose, retaining in-person work where collaboration and trust are essential.

Practice count: source 175 words -> one-third target about 58 words -> model 59 words. This illustrates the required recount after drafting.

6. Self-check rubric

Criterion	Question
Fidelity	Did I preserve the author's meaning and qualification?
Coverage	Are all major idea units and the conclusion present?
Compression	Is the final count near the calculated target?
Independence	Have I rewritten structure and wording where possible?
Coherence	Does it read as connected prose rather than notes?
Correctness	Are grammar, punctuation and title instructions accurate?

PART 12 - 07 Short-Essay-Writing

1. Choose the question you can qualify and develop

The 600-word essay is a continuous argument, not a GS answer copied under headings. Choose the topic for which you can write a balanced thesis, four distinct paragraphs and safe examples in clear English.

Choice test	Ask before choosing	Reject the topic if...
Meaning	Can I restate every key word?	A key abstraction remains vague
Position	Can I make a qualified claim, not a slogan?	I can only agree or disagree absolutely
Development	Can I see four non-repeating moves?	All points are synonyms
Examples	Can I use ordinary, defensible illustrations?	I would need invented statistics or quotations
Language	Can I explain it in plain English?	I would rely on memorised ornament

2. Decode the topic and form a qualified thesis

Topic -> key terms -> hidden tension -> qualified position
-> reasons / consequence / limitation -> direction

Prompt	Decode	Weak thesis	Qualified thesis
Convenience without responsibility weakens citizenship.	Convenience, responsibility, citizenship	Convenience is bad.	Convenience can expand access, but when it removes responsibility for shared consequences it turns citizens into passive consumers.
Technology can widen opportunity as well as inequality.	Technology, opportunity, inequality, "as well as"	Technology is useful.	Technology expands reach only where affordability, skills, accessible design and accountable institutions prevent existing disadvantages from being digitised.
Reading is an exercise in freedom.	Reading, exercise, freedom	Reading gives freedom.	Reading enlarges freedom by exposing a mind to alternatives, but this freedom requires time, literacy and the willingness to question one's own assumptions.

3. Plan in six minutes

Minute	Action	Output
1	Decode the wording	Key terms and scope
2	Write one-sentence thesis	Claim + qualification
3-4	Build four body moves	Reason, mechanism, consequence, response
5	Add counterargument/limit	A real concession, not "everything has pros and cons"
6	Choose conclusion direction	Return to thesis with a practical judgement

Reliable architecture

INTRODUCTION: interpret topic + qualified thesis

BODY 1: first reason/mechanism

BODY 2: second reason/consequence

BODY 3: counterargument, limit or trade-off

BODY 4: response, condition or institutional implication

CONCLUSION: reasoned final judgement

Each body paragraph uses:

claim -> explanation -> safe example -> link back to thesis

4. Drafting control

- Open with the issue, not a quotation, dictionary definition or "Since ancient times".
- State the thesis by the end of the introduction.
- Give each paragraph one controlling idea and a linking first sentence.
- Use *however*, *therefore*, *for example*, *consequently*, *yet* only where the logic requires them.
- Make the counterargument meaningful, then answer or limit it.
- Use first person sparingly; avoid rhetorical questions and exclamation marks.
- Prefer a 12-25 word sentence; split a sentence when the subject, verb or reference becomes unclear.

5. Examples: useful, safe and analytical

Example type	Safe use	Unsafe use
Everyday public- and service illustration	"A missed complaint response can make a service unusable for a worker who cannot return repeatedly."	Invented percentage or programme outcome
Broad, established social example	"A library permits a reader to encounter views beyond the immediate community."	Unverified quotation attributed to a famous person
Personal- and observed illustration	Use briefly to illuminate a general point	Replace the argument with autobiography
Current example	Use only if source- and date are verified and necessary	Guess a statistic, year, budget or law

An example earns its place only if you explain **why it supports the claim**. One precise illustration is better than a list of names.

6. Word-count and revision checkpoints

For practice, count space-separated words; treat a hyphenated expression as one word. A title is not part of the count. This is a coaching method, not a published UPSC count convention.

Stage	Approximate running count	Check
Introduction	70-90	Thesis is visible
Four body paragraphs	420-460	Each has a distinct job
Conclusion	60-80	Verdict follows from argument
Final	About 600	Count, then remove repetition rather than substance

Five-minute revision sweep

1. Underline the thesis and the counterargument. If either is missing, repair it first.
2. Check that each paragraph advances-not repeats-the thesis.
3. Remove one decorative sentence and one unsupported claim.
4. Check agreement, tense, articles, prepositions, commas and pronoun reference.
5. Count words; cut duplicate examples before cutting the conclusion.

7. Annotated model essay 1

Prompt: Public institutions earn trust through everyday conduct.

Public trust is often discussed after a spectacular failure or a major announcement. Yet citizens usually form their judgement through ordinary encounters: whether an application is acknowledged, whether a bus arrives when it is expected, whether a hospital explains a delay, and whether an official treats a complainant with respect. Public institutions cannot avoid difficult decisions, but they earn trust when their daily conduct is reliable, intelligible and fair.

Reliability is the first condition. A rule may be sound on paper, but it inspires little confidence if its operation depends on the citizen knowing whom to call or how often to visit an office. Predictable hours, clear documents and timely responses reduce this uncertainty. They also matter most to people with little spare time or money. For a salaried worker, a delayed certificate may mean more than inconvenience; it may require a lost day's wage. Regular service therefore communicates that public authority recognises the cost of delay borne by ordinary people.

Trust also depends on explanation. Not every request can be granted, and not every public service can be immediate. A reasoned refusal, however, is different from silence. When an institution states the rule, identifies the missing information and indicates a route for review, it allows the citizen to understand a decision even while disagreeing with it. This does not make the decision automatically just. It does make power more accountable because the official must connect an action to reasons that others can examine.

Fair conduct is equally important. A queue loses legitimacy when people believe that influence, familiarity or persistence matters more than the announced rule. Equal treatment does not mean ignoring genuine differences of need; a hospital may properly prioritise an emergency. It means that a difference must rest on a relevant reason rather than personal preference. Visible reasons, simple procedures and an accessible complaint channel help distinguish justified priority from favouritism.

Everyday conduct also produces information that an institution needs in order to improve. A complaint is not merely an inconvenience to be cleared from a register. Repeated questions about one form may show that its language is unclear. Frequent visits to the same counter may reveal that offices have divided a process in a way that citizens cannot understand. Staff who listen carefully can turn these encounters into modest corrections before frustration becomes distrust. Publishing what has changed is important: it tells the public that speaking up has an effect without pretending that every request can be accepted.

Consistency is crucial because one courteous encounter cannot compensate for a process that is unpredictable elsewhere. Citizens judge an institution across connected steps: notice, application, response, appeal and final service. A clear first step loses value if the next office cannot find the record. Everyday trust is therefore cumulative.

There is a limit to what everyday conduct can achieve. Trust cannot be manufactured by polite language if an institution is corrupt, chronically underfunded or directed by an unjust policy. Nor should citizens trust without question. Scrutiny, independent review and a free press remain necessary precisely because institutions exercise power. Still, these safeguards work better when routine records are accurate and staff do not treat the public as an interruption.

The strongest public institutions are not those that promise perfection. They are those whose ordinary actions allow citizens to predict what will happen, ask why it happened and seek correction when it goes wrong. Such conduct turns authority from a distant claim into an experienced public relationship. Trust then becomes neither blind loyalty nor public relations, but a reasonable response to dependable and fair administration.

Practice count: 597 words (title excluded). **Annotation:** Thesis in paragraph 1; reliability, explanation and fairness are distinct mechanisms; paragraph 6 is a genuine limitation; conclusion gives a qualified verdict. **Coaching score:** 88/100 - relevance/thesis 18, organisation 18, development/balance 22, grammar/vocabulary 23, conclusion/count

discipline 7. The band is an internal model, not an official marking key.

8. Annotated model essay 2

Prompt: Technology can widen opportunity as well as inequality.

Technology is often praised as if access to a device automatically creates opportunity. A phone can indeed connect a student to a lesson, a worker to a vacancy and a patient to information that was previously distant. But the same system can exclude people who lack a stable connection, usable language, confidence with forms or protection from error. Technology widens opportunity only when its design and surrounding institutions prevent old disadvantages from being reproduced in a digital form.

Its potential is real because distance and time can be reduced. A learner in a small town can consult material that would once have been available only in a large library. A person seeking work can learn about openings without travelling repeatedly. Digital payments can make small transactions easier to record and complete. In each case, the benefit is not the screen itself but the wider reach of information and services. Technology becomes valuable when it lowers a genuine barrier.

However, a new channel can create a new gatekeeper. An online application that assumes fluent English, constant data access and the ability to upload documents may be simpler for the office but harder for the applicant. A disabled user may be excluded if a site cannot be read by assistive tools. An automated decision can also appear neutral while repeating biased data or leaving no clear path to challenge an error. Efficiency for the provider is therefore not proof of accessibility for the public.

The answer is not to reject technology or to preserve every paper process. It is to build alternatives and accountability into the system. Assisted help desks, clear language, offline routes for essential services and a human appeal channel can prevent a digital process from becoming a barrier. Designers should test a service with people who have different levels of literacy, income and physical access. Institutions must also explain how data are used and correct mistakes promptly, because a fast error can harm more people than a slow one.

Access must also be understood as a continuing condition rather than a one-time delivery of a device or an application. A service may be technically available but practically inaccessible when it consumes costly data, changes without warning or requires repeated authentication that a user cannot complete. Public systems should therefore measure successful completion and user understanding, not only registration or download. This approach does not make every service equally easy, but it makes exclusion visible early enough for a remedy.

The same discipline applies to private platforms that increasingly mediate ordinary life. Their convenience should not excuse confusing consent, unexplained recommendations or systems that leave a person unable to correct a damaging record. People need enough information and practical control to understand the choices they are making. This is not a demand that every user become a technical expert. It is a demand that powerful systems do not convert complexity into helplessness.

Some inequality would exist even without technology, and no application can solve unequal schooling, income or social power by itself. This is precisely why exaggerated promises are dangerous. A digital service should be judged by whether it expands a person's real ability to learn, work or obtain a service, not by the number of downloads or transactions it records.

Technology is therefore neither an automatic equaliser nor an inevitable source of division. It is a tool whose social effect depends on access, design and accountability. When these conditions are taken seriously, digital systems can extend opportunity. When they are ignored, technology gives existing inequality a quicker and less visible form.

Practice count: 593 words (title excluded). **Annotation:** The thesis qualifies both sides; paragraphs 2-5 move from benefit to mechanism of exclusion to response; paragraph 6 limits technological claims. **Coaching score:** 87/100 - relevance/thesis 18, organisation 18, development/balance 22, grammar/vocabulary 22, conclusion/count discipline 7.